An Adriatic–Ionian Manufacturing Council: Making Southern Europe a Global Factory

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Policy paper

Executive summary

European manufacturers are shortening their supply chains, and the shipping route through the Suez Canal is reopening after two years of disruption. Together these trends raise a practical question for policymakers: where in Europe's neighbourhood should the next generation of export manufacturing be located? This paper argues that the countries of the Adriatic and Ionian seas (Italy, Slovenia, Croatia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Montenegro, Albania and Greece) form the strongest candidate. The region combines the shortest maritime route from Asia and the Gulf into central Europe, an established engineering base in northern Italy and Slovenia, and labour costs on the eastern shore that remain well below the EU average.

The region's weakness is institutional rather than economic. Seven governments plan industrial policy separately, compete for the same investors and operate separate customs, rail and energy systems. Anneer Center therefore proposes the creation of an **Adriatic–Ionian Manufacturing Council**, an intergovernmental body with a mandate limited to manufacturing. Its central function would be to agree a division of industrial specialisation among members, so that each country builds depth in a defined set of sectors and supplies the others within an integrated regional production system.

Key findings

1. Ships from Asia reach the northern Adriatic ports after a voyage roughly 2,000 nautical miles shorter than to Hamburg or Rotterdam, with door-to-port transit times five to eight days shorter [1][2].
2. The region's container ports are growing but remain small. Koper, Trieste and Rijeka together handled under 2.4 million TEU in 2024, well below their market potential [3].
3. Average gross monthly wages on the eastern shore ranged from about €860 in Albania to €2,016 in Croatia in 2025, between a third and three-quarters of the euro-area average [18][19][20][37].
4. On cost alone the Adriatic–Ionian region does not beat Morocco or Turkey, and central Europe is more deeply integrated into German supply chains. The region's advantage lies in a combination no competitor offers: an EU legal framework or accession path for every member, the shortest sea link from Asia and the Gulf into central Europe, and a full range of production costs within one region.

5. Six of the seven countries already use the euro or a currency pegged to it, which removes most exchange-rate risk from cross-border production.
6. An illustrative Anneer Center calculation suggests that if Bosnia and Herzegovina, Montenegro and Albania attracted foreign investment per head at Serbia's 2025 rate, they would receive around €3.3 billion a year.
7. The principal obstacles (energy costs, fragmented logistics, small firm size, non-EU borders and labour shortages) are largely problems of coordination that a regional body is suited to address.

1. Introduction

Europe's search for closer and more secure suppliers is now measurable. One industry tracker found that nearshoring and reshoring accounted for a record 14 per cent of EU sourcing in the first quarter of 2026, with sourcing from the Mediterranean up 25 per cent year on year [6]. Most analysis of this shift has focused on individual countries such as Poland, Spain, Morocco and Turkey. Less attention has been paid to the possibility that a group of smaller neighbouring economies, acting together, could offer investors a more complete proposition than any of them alone.

This paper examines the Adriatic–Ionian region in that light. It assesses the region's geographic and industrial assets, identifies the constraints that have prevented it from becoming a major manufacturing location, and sets out an institutional proposal to address them. The analysis draws on port, labour-market and industrial data published by national statistical offices, Eurostat, the OECD, the IMF and industry sources.

We define the region as the seven states bordering the Adriatic and Ionian seas: Italy, Slovenia, Croatia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Montenegro, Albania and Greece. This follows the geography of the EU Strategy for the Adriatic and Ionian Region (EUSAIR), adopted in 2014, which also includes Serbia, North Macedonia and San Marino [39]. Most of the port and trade analysis concerns the Adriatic, the sea that reaches furthest into central Europe; Greece's western ports on the Ionian Sea form the region's southern gateway.

2. Geography as an industrial asset

The Adriatic extends some 800 kilometres north-west from the Strait of Otranto into the European mainland. Its northern ports sit closer to the industrial centres of southern Germany, Austria, the Czech Republic, Slovakia and Hungary than any North Sea port does by sea. For cargo moving between Asia and central Europe via Suez, the Adriatic route is about 2,000 nautical miles shorter than the route to the North Range ports, saving six to eight days of sailing [1]. Freight forwarders operating dedicated services

report average transit times five to eight days shorter than via Hamburg or Bremerhaven [2], and recent research estimates that redirecting container flows through the northern Adriatic would cut fuel consumption by about 20 per cent [3].

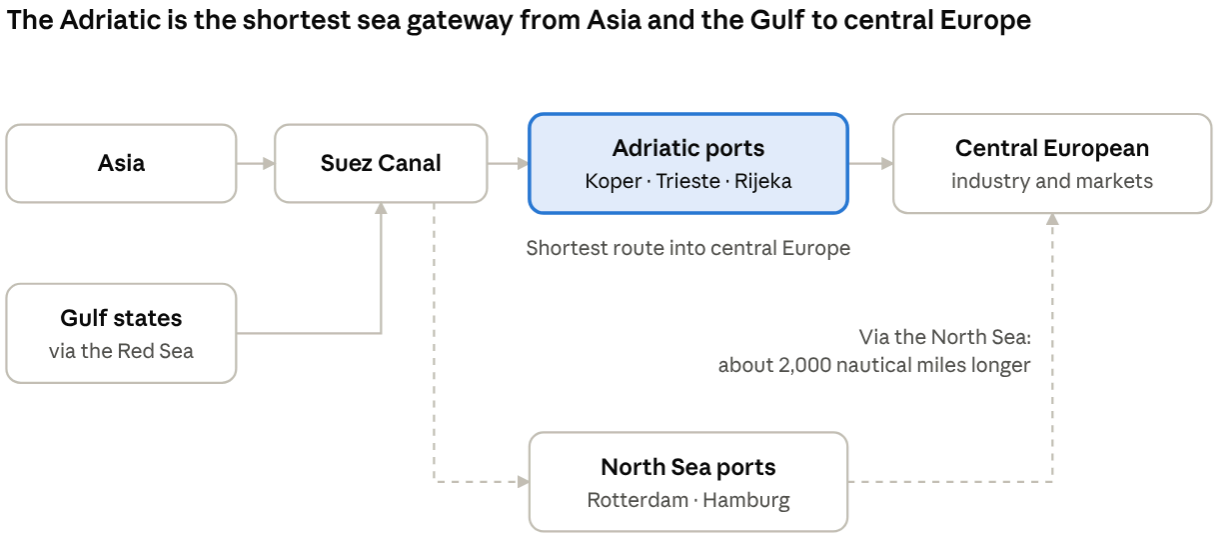


Figure 1. Main sea routes from Asia and the Gulf to central Europe · schematic, not to scale

This advantage depends on the Suez route, which carried around 12 per cent of global seaborne trade before the Red Sea crisis [4]. Container capacity transiting the canal has recovered to more than half of pre-crisis levels, following the return of major Asia–Mediterranean services in mid-2026 [5]. A sustained recovery would restore the Adriatic's position as the natural entry point for Asian cargo bound for central Europe, and as an exit point for European goods bound for the Gulf, South Asia and East Africa.

The port infrastructure to handle larger volumes is already being built (Table 1).

Table 1. Selected Adriatic and Ionian ports

Port	Country	Recent indicator	Note
Koper	Slovenia	1.27 million TEU in 2025, up 12% [7]	Largest container port in the northern Adriatic
Trieste	Italy	Almost 60 million tonnes of cargo in 2025 [8]	Italy's largest cargo port and main rail gateway to central Europe
Rijeka	Croatia	New Rijeka Gateway terminal opened October 2025 [9]	Built for vessels of up to 24,000 TEU; Maersk is a shareholder
Ravenna, Ancona, Bari	Italy	Ravenna cargo up 9.6% in 2025 [8]	Bulk, ro-ro and regional container services

Port	Country	Recent indicator	Note
Bar, Durrës	Montenegro, Albania	Smaller regional ports	Gateways for the southern Western Balkans
Igoumenitsa, Patras	Greece	Ionian ferry and ro-ro ports	Direct ferry links to Ancona, Bari, Brindisi and Venice

Volumes remain modest by European standards, and growth is uneven. In 2025, following the reorganisation of global shipping alliances, Koper and Rijeka grew by 12 and 15 per cent respectively while Trieste lost transshipment volumes [10]. The ports compete for the same deep-sea services rather than coordinating, and freight forwarders have long reported that slow customs clearance can offset the time saved at sea [12].

Greece's principal container port lies outside the two seas. Piraeus, on the Aegean, handled about 4.6 million TEU in 2025 and remains one of Europe's five largest container ports, despite two years of traffic losses caused by the Red Sea disruption [40][41]. For the Council, Piraeus would serve as Greece's main deep-sea gateway, complementing the Ionian ferry ports that link Greece directly to the Italian Adriatic coast.

The more significant gap is that little of the cargo passing through the region is processed there. The contrast with Morocco is instructive. Tanger Med handled a record 11.1 million TEU in 2025, and a growing share of its traffic is generated by manufacturing built around the port, particularly in the automotive sector [11]. Tanger Med is a single national project; the Adriatic–Ionian region has seven countries' worth of ports and industrial capacity but no comparable strategy linking them.

3. The region's industrial base

The Adriatic–Ionian economies differ widely in income, industrial depth and labour costs. For the purpose of building an integrated production system, these differences are an asset.

The northern shore contains one of Europe's densest manufacturing regions. Italy's north-east (Friuli Venezia Giulia, Veneto and Emilia-Romagna) and the Marche are centres of machinery, packaging equipment, automotive components, furniture and food processing. Slovenia is the most industrialised economy on the eastern shore. Manufacturing accounts for about a fifth of its GDP [17]; pharmaceuticals and electronics are its fastest-growing sectors [15]; and its share of medium- and high-tech exports exceeds the EU average [16]. Its industrial base includes the pharmaceutical groups Krka and Lek and Renault's Revoz assembly plant in Novo Mesto.

The eastern shore offers lower costs and an industrial base that is growing from a smaller starting point (Table 2). Research by the Vienna Institute for International Economic Studies (wiiw) finds that nearshoring is under way in the Western Balkans, with foreign direct investment into Bosnia and Herzegovina, Kosovo and North Macedonia between 2020 and 2023 well above its long-term average [13]. Western European firms that relocated production to the region typically chose it over Asia because of lower production costs and proximity to the EU [14].

Table 2. Manufacturing and wages on the eastern shore

Country	Manufacturing, % of GDP (2024) [17]	Average gross monthly wage, 2025
Slovenia	19.2	n/a
Bosnia and Herzegovina	11.6	€1,245 [19]
Croatia	10.8	€2,016 [20]
Albania	6.2	€860 [18]
Montenegro	n/a	€1,206 [19]

For comparison, average hourly labour costs in 2025 were €34.9 in the EU and €38.2 in the euro area; Greece recorded €18.2 [21]. Wage growth is rapid, however. Croatia's hourly labour costs rose 11.6 per cent in 2025 and Slovenia's 9.3 per cent [21], and the cost advantage of the eastern shore should not be assumed to be permanent.

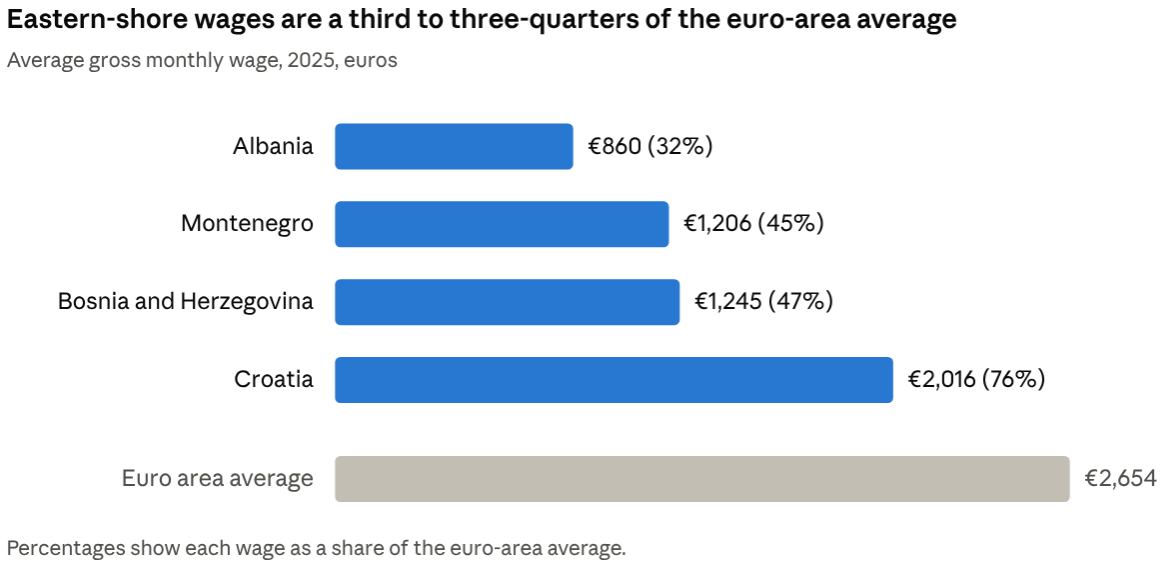


Figure 2. Sources: INSTAT, BHAS, MONSTAT, Croatian Bureau of Statistics; euro-area average from Eurostat data via Trading Economics · 2025

Greece adds a recovering industrial economy at the southern approach. Its industrial exports rose from about €28 billion in 2017 to about €49 billion in 2024, led by pharmaceuticals, metals and food processing [25].

Taken together, the region contains the components of a regional production system comparable to the one that linked German industry with central European suppliers after 2004: design and advanced engineering on one side, competitive production capacity on the other, and short transport links between them.

4. How the Adriatic–Ionian region compares with competing locations

Anneer Center's assessment that the Adriatic–Ionian region is the best-placed region for export manufacturing has to be tested against the alternatives that investors actually consider. Table 4 compares the region with the four locations most often cited in European nearshoring decisions.

Table 4. The Adriatic–Ionian region and competing nearshoring locations

Location	Access to the EU market	Position on the Asia–Europe sea route	Labour cost indicator	Main limitation
Adriatic–Ionian (eastern shore)	EU members or EU candidates	Shortest route into central Europe via Suez	Gross monthly wages €860–€2,016 (2025) [18][19][20]	Fragmented ports, borders and industrial policy
Central Europe (Poland, Hungary, Romania)	EU members	Served mainly through North Sea ports or long rail routes	Hourly labour costs €13.6 in Romania and €15.2 in Hungary (2025) [32]	Rising wages; distant from the Suez route
Morocco	Free trade in industrial goods under the EU Association Agreement	Strait of Gibraltar, on the route to northern Europe	Estimated manufacturing cost about $2.8 an hour (2025) [30]	Far from central European markets by land; narrower supplier base

Location	Access to the EU market	Position on the Asia–Europe sea route	Labour cost indicator	Main limitation
Turkey	Customs union with the EU for industrial goods	Eastern Mediterranean, close to Suez	Estimated manufacturing cost about $4.8 an hour (2025) [30]	Inflation, high interest rates and currency volatility [31]
Iberia (Spain, Portugal)	EU members	Western Mediterranean	Estimated manufacturing cost about $6.3 an hour in Portugal (2025) [30]	Peripheral to central European markets

On any single criterion, the region is not the leader. Morocco and Turkey offer lower labour costs, and a survey of more than 250 car plants found that Morocco had the world's lowest assembly labour cost per vehicle in 2024, at $106 [29]. Central Europe is more deeply integrated into German supply chains. Spain has cheaper industrial electricity than Italy [22].

The Adriatic–Ionian case rests on a combination that none of its competitors offers. Morocco and Turkey have cost advantages but sit outside the EU's legal and regulatory system, and Turkish manufacturers have faced high inflation, high interest rates and closures in labour-intensive sectors [31]. Central Europe is inside the EU but has largely used up its cost advantage, and it is supplied from Asia through North Sea ports or long rail routes. Iberia is on the edge of the central European market. The Adriatic–Ionian region is the only location that combines three things: EU membership or a formal accession path for every member; the shortest sea link from Asia and the Gulf into central Europe; and a wide range of production costs within one region, which allows the high-value and labour-intensive stages of the same value chain to sit within a few hundred kilometres of each other. This combination, rather than any single factor, is the basis of Anneer Center's assessment.

5. Constraints

Five constraints explain why the region has not yet realised this potential.

Energy costs. Italian companies paid an average of €278 per megawatt-hour for electricity in the first half of 2025, against €183 in France and €171 in Spain [22]. The main cause is structural: natural gas sets the Italian wholesale price in about 70 per cent of hours [23].

The eastern shore has substantial hydro, wind and solar potential, but limited interconnection prevents the two sides from benefiting from each other's resources.

Fragmented logistics. Ports, railways and customs administrations are organised nationally. Rail connections from Rijeka to its hinterland remain weak [10], and investors face seven sets of permitting and border procedures.

Firm size. According to the OECD, micro and small firms account for more than 60 per cent of employment in Italy, against around 40 per cent in France and Germany, and their productivity lags that of larger firms by a wider margin than in other large European economies [24]. Small firms predominate across the Western Balkans as well, limiting investment in automation, research and export capacity.

Borders. Italy, Slovenia, Croatia and Greece belong to the EU single market. Bosnia and Herzegovina, Montenegro and Albania do not, and goods crossing between them face customs controls and differing technical standards.

Labour supply and policy stability. Labour markets in Slovenia and Croatia are tight [16], while the Western Balkans have experienced sustained emigration of working-age people. Greece demonstrates that the trend can be reversed: around 473,000 citizens who emigrated over the past decade and a half have returned, supported by tax incentives [26]. Policy volatility is a further deterrent. Italy's Transizione 5.0 investment incentive was launched in 2024 with €6.3 billion, reduced to €2.5 billion in 2025 and then partially restored [27][28].

Each of these constraints can be addressed nationally to some degree. Most, however, are more efficiently addressed through coordination among neighbouring states.

6. The proposal: an Adriatic–Ionian Manufacturing Council

Anneer Center proposes that the governments of Italy, Slovenia, Croatia, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Montenegro, Albania and Greece establish an Adriatic–Ionian Manufacturing Council by treaty or joint declaration. The Council's mandate would be confined to manufacturing and its supporting infrastructure. It would have no role in foreign, security or monetary policy.

Serbia should be invited to join as an associate member. Although it has no coastline, it is the largest destination for manufacturing investment in the Western Balkans. Foreign direct investment reached a record €4.5 billion in 2023, more than half of all inflows to the region [33], and remained at €3.5 billion in 2025 [34]. Serbia is linked to the Adriatic by the Belgrade–Bar railway and by road corridors to the Croatian and Montenegrin coasts. Associate status would allow it to take part in the industrial map and the investment fund, while full membership remained with the coastal states.

The Council need not start from nothing. The EU Strategy for the Adriatic and Ionian Region already brings these governments together, with work centred on the maritime economy, transport and energy links, the environment and tourism [39]. The Council would add what that framework lacks: a dedicated manufacturing mandate, an agreed division of industrial specialisation and its own investment instruments. North Macedonia, also part of the EU strategy, could join Serbia as an associate member.

We suggest a light structure: an annual summit of heads of government to set strategy; a council of industry and economy ministers meeting quarterly; and a small permanent secretariat, located in one of the region's port cities, to prepare decisions and monitor implementation. The European Commission, the European Investment Bank and the European Bank for Reconstruction and Development would participate as observers and financing partners.

The Council would not require a new currency. Italy, Slovenia, Croatia and Greece are members of the euro area; Montenegro uses the euro as its legal tender; and the Bosnian convertible mark is pegged to the euro. Only the Albanian lek floats freely. Few regional groupings begin with this degree of monetary alignment.

The Council would complement, not replace, EU structures. For the three non-EU members it would operate alongside existing accession processes and the EU's Growth Plan for the Western Balkans, and could accelerate their practical integration into European supply chains ahead of formal membership.

What each member gains

The Council will be agreed only if each government can see a clear return.

Italy has the most to contribute and a strong reason to lead. The IMF expects the Italian economy to grow by only 0.5 per cent in 2026 [38], and Italian manufacturers face some of the highest energy costs in Europe. Germany's industrial strength has long rested in part on supply chains extending into lower-cost neighbouring economies in central Europe. Italian industry has no comparable integrated hinterland on that scale, and the Adriatic–Ionian region can provide one. Italian companies are already among the largest investors in the region, accounting for about 12 per cent of foreign investment in Serbia in official Serbian data [36]. The Council would also bring more cargo to Trieste, Venice, Ravenna, Ancona and Bari, and new electricity links, building on the existing undersea cable between Italy and Montenegro, could give Italian industry access to Balkan renewable power.

Slovenia and Croatia would gain a larger market for their specialised suppliers and a stronger role for Koper and Rijeka as gateways to central Europe.

Bosnia and Herzegovina, Montenegro and Albania would gain investment, technology and a practical route into European supply chains ahead of EU membership.

Greece would gain closer links between its growing pharmaceutical and metals industries and central European buyers.

7. Specialisation and integration

The Council's distinctive function would be to agree a division of industrial specialisation among its members. Under the current arrangement, each country tries to attract investment in every sector and competes on incentives. Under the proposed arrangement, each member would be designated the region's lead location for a defined set of industries, would concentrate its training, infrastructure and incentives on them, and would supply the other members.

Table 3 sets out an illustrative allocation based on each country's existing industrial assets. It is intended as a basis for negotiation, not a final assignment.

Table 3. Illustrative allocation of lead sectors

Country	Proposed lead sectors	Existing anchors
Italy	Industrial machinery and robotics; automotive and EV engineering; food technology; final assembly of complex products	Machinery and component clusters in the north-east
Slovenia	Pharmaceuticals; electronics and household appliances; automotive components	Krka, Lek, Revoz; Port of Koper
Croatia	Electrical and power-grid equipment; shipbuilding and maritime equipment; food processing	Electrical engineering base; shipyards; Port of Rijeka
Bosnia and Herzegovina	Metals and metalworking; wood and furniture; automotive parts	Metal-processing and furniture export industries
Montenegro	Light metals; renewable-energy generation; port logistics	Aluminium industry in Podgorica; Port of Bar
Albania	Textiles, clothing and footwear; mineral processing; agrifood	Established garment and footwear sector; chromium ore; Port of Durrës

Country	Proposed lead sectors	Existing anchors
Greece	Generic pharmaceuticals; aluminium and metals; refined petroleum products	Pharmaceutical and aluminium producers; shipping sector
Serbia (associate member)	Automotive assembly and components; machinery; electrical equipment	Stellantis plant in Kragujevac; largest FDI destination in the Western Balkans [33]

In practice, specialisation would allow value chains to be organised across borders. An electric-vehicle component chain, for example, could combine engineering and final assembly in northern Italy, power electronics in Slovenia, castings and metal parts from Bosnia and Herzegovina, wiring harnesses assembled in Albania, and export through Koper or Rijeka. Each country would build scale in its own segment; the region as a whole would offer investors a complete chain within a short distance.

Specialisation without central planning

Allocating industries among countries has an unhappy precedent. From the early 1960s the Soviet-led Council for Mutual Economic Assistance (Comecon) tried to assign each member state a specialised role within a "socialist division of labour". The system failed for well-understood reasons. Allocations were made by planners rather than prices; production targets were binding; members were shielded from outside competition; and countries assigned low-value roles resisted. Romania, in particular, refused to be confined to agriculture and raw materials.

The Adriatic–Ionian Manufacturing Council would differ on each of these points. Participation would be voluntary and the industrial map open to revision. The map would guide public incentives, training and infrastructure, but private firms would remain free to invest in any sector in any member country. Members would continue to trade openly with the rest of the world under EU and World Trade Organization rules. And every member would be guaranteed a share of high-value activity. The closer models are market-based ones: the EU's own smart specialisation strategies, under which regions concentrate public support on sectors where they have an advantage, and Airbus, where national specialisation emerged from commercial agreement rather than political decree.

8. Instruments

The Council would need five instruments to carry out its mandate:

1. **A regional industrial map**, agreed by members and reviewed every five years, setting lead sectors and guiding public investment and incentives.

2. **An Adriatic–Ionian Industrial Investment Fund**, capitalised by member states, European development banks and external investors, to finance industrial zones, shared infrastructure and anchor projects in designated sectors.
3. **Trade facilitation among members**, including mutual recognition of product certifications, common standards and a shared digital customs window, extended to non-EU members as far as EU law allows.
4. **A joint investment promotion agency**, offering investors a single point of contact for the region in place of seven competing national agencies.
5. **Regional infrastructure planning**, covering freight rail to central Europe, electricity interconnectors between Italy and the eastern shore, and industrial zones adjacent to the main ports.

The scale of the opportunity

The potential gain can be illustrated with a simple benchmark. In 2025 Bosnia and Herzegovina received foreign direct investment of KM 1.41 billion, or about €720 million [35], roughly €225 per inhabitant. Serbia received €3.5 billion [34], roughly €530 per inhabitant. If Bosnia and Herzegovina, Montenegro and Albania, with a combined population of about 6.2 million, attracted investment at Serbia's per-capita rate, they would receive around €3.3 billion a year, or more than €30 billion over a decade.

This is an illustrative calculation by Anneer Center, not a forecast. It assumes the three countries could match Serbia's recent investment performance, and it excludes any additional investment the Council might attract to Italy, Slovenia, Croatia and Greece. It nonetheless indicates the order of magnitude at stake.

9. Risks and objections

The proposal raises several legitimate concerns.

Unequal outcomes. An allocation that concentrates engineering and research in Italy and Slovenia and assembly in the Western Balkans would entrench existing income gaps. The industrial map should ensure that every member receives at least one high-value sector, and the Council should report progress on wages and productivity in each member, not only on aggregate output.

Sovereignty and rigidity. Governments are unlikely to accept binding restrictions on the industries they may pursue. The map should therefore guide public incentives and joint investment rather than prohibit private activity, and should be revised as economies develop.

Compatibility with EU law. EU state-aid and trade rules constrain what member states can agree with non-members. The Council's design would need to be developed with the European Commission from the outset.

Slow decision-making. Some members have complex internal governance. In Bosnia and Herzegovina, much economic policy is set by its two entities rather than at state level, which could delay the country's participation. The Council should therefore allow members to join individual instruments, such as the investment fund or trade facilitation, as they become ready, rather than requiring every member to adopt everything at once.

Rising costs. Wage growth on the eastern shore is among the fastest in Europe [21]. A strategy based on low labour costs alone would have a limited life; the case for the region must rest increasingly on location, skills and integration.

Investor response. No intergovernmental body can compel private investment. The Council's measure of success would be whether it reduces the cost, time and uncertainty of producing in the region enough to change investment decisions.

10. The Gulf dimension

The Adriatic–Ionian region and the Gulf are linked by the Red Sea and Suez corridor, and the proposed India–Middle East–Europe Economic Corridor would add rail and port connections between them. Gulf states have the capital, energy resources and industrial diversification goals that a regional manufacturing strategy requires; the region offers skilled labour, an EU-adjacent location and access to European markets. Gulf sovereign funds and industrial groups are natural candidates to co-invest in the proposed Investment Fund and in anchor projects, and Gulf manufacturers seeking a European production base could find the region more accessible than locations in northern Europe.

11. Recommendations

For Adriatic–Ionian governments

1. Convene a leaders' meeting to agree in principle on an Adriatic–Ionian Manufacturing Council, and task ministers with preparing its founding framework within twelve months.
2. Commission a joint study of each country's industrial strengths as the basis for the first regional industrial map.
3. Commit to keeping core investment incentives stable for at least ten years.

For the European Union

4. Support the Council as a vehicle for the gradual integration of Bosnia and Herzegovina, Montenegro and Albania into the single market for industrial goods.
5. Prioritise Adriatic–Ionian rail and electricity interconnection projects within existing EU infrastructure programmes.

For investors, including those from the Gulf

6. Engage early as founding partners in the Adriatic–Ionian Industrial Investment Fund.
7. Evaluate the Adriatic–Ionian region as a single production location rather than as seven separate national markets.

Conclusion

The Adriatic–Ionian countries possess an unusual combination of advantages: the shortest maritime link between Asia and central Europe, complementary levels of industrial development and cost, and near-complete monetary alignment. What has been missing is a mechanism for using these advantages collectively. An Adriatic–Ionian Manufacturing Council, limited in scope and built around agreed specialisation, would provide that mechanism. Anneer Center believes that, with such coordination, the Adriatic–Ionian region is better placed than any other region to become a leading global manufacturing hub.

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